High success rates

Deciding when students are ready for independence

Use success-rate evidence to judge whether practice is productive and students are ready for greater independence. Interpret accuracy alongside reasoning, task demand and the distribution of errors.

How to do it well

1 Sequence for early success. Teach one manageable component at a time and anticipate misconceptions before complexity is added.

2 Model and guide. Make an accurate first example visible, then co-construct and rehearse several short examples with high participation.

3 Check accuracy and reasoning. Use all-pupil responses, short quizzes or sampled work to estimate the class success rate and the pattern of errors.

4 Adjust support or challenge. Below the productive range, re-model, shrink the step or restore a scaffold. When accuracy is consistently above about 90%, fade support or add depth, variation or transfer.

5 Reinforce and revisit. Use immediate correction, later retrieval and spaced practice so accurate responses become fluent and durable.

What this sounds like

“The answers are mostly accurate. Before you work independently, explain the first decision on a new example. I will check the remaining gaps while you practise.”

Classroom example. Most guided answers are correct, but several students have copied a visible method without explaining the first decision. The teacher uses a distinct example and collects reasoning before release. Secure pupils receive a useful variation while the remaining group gets targeted guidance. Readiness is judged from the demand and pattern, not the percentage alone.

Top tips that make the technique work

Treat percentages as signals. Around 80% can be a useful practical reference in some tasks, not a universal rule or guarantee of readiness.

Inspect what the errors concern. A small minority missing a crucial prerequisite still needs follow-up.

Distinguish accuracy from copying. Success with an identical example or visible answer can exaggerate competence.

Increase challenge when secure. Fade support, change a condition or require explanation instead of assigning more of the same.

Return to the learning. Initial success is a starting point for fluency and later retrieval, not proof of permanent mastery.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Use accuracy, reasoning and task structure together.	Mechanical release at a fixed percentage.
Adjust support before repeated failure.	Making every practice task trivial to achieve high scores.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

DistillED — Obtain a High Success Rate